

2.5 · Personal Agent Workshop

Week 2 · Tuesday Jul 21 — Data, Environment, and
Human-Centered Sustainable AI

Generative AI & Sustainability · Munich Summer
School 2026



CAL POLY



Session goal

Set up an agent that works in a folder on your computer, then use it to build and review a small privacy-first prototype.

By the end, you should have:

- one working agent: **Codex** or **GitHub Copilot**
- one dedicated project folder with persistent instructions
- one local prototype you can open and explain
- one record of what the agent changed, tested, and could not verify

An agent can act on your computer

A chatbot (website)

- answers in a conversation
- may not see your files
- gives you code to copy

A co-work agent

- reads files in a project
- proposes and makes edits
- runs programs (if allowed)
- reports results for your review

- **The important shift is not better autocomplete. It is giving a model tools and a bounded place to act.**

Tips for Human-Agent interaction

1. **You define the outcome and boundaries.**
2. The agent inspects the project and proposes a plan.
3. The agent reads, edits, and runs tools within its permissions.
4. **You inspect evidence:** changed files, command output, and behavior.
5. You accept, revise, or undo the work.

- **An agent's confident summary is not verification. Check the artifact.**



Choose one path

If you have...	Use...	Where you work
a ChatGPT account with Codex access	Codex CLI	terminal
a GitHub account	Copilot CLI	terminal

- Work with the tool you can access today; the workshop prompts are tool-neutral.

First, know where you are

The terminal is a text interface to your files and programs.

The terminal - text interface to file system

macOS

Open **Terminal** with Spotlight (Cmd + Space).

Windows

Open **PowerShell** from the Start menu or Windows Terminal.

Six commands are enough to begin

Command	What it does
<code>pwd</code>	show the current folder
<code>ls</code>	list files and folders
<code>cd folder-name</code>	enter a folder
<code>cd ..</code>	move up one folder
<code>mkdir project-name</code>	create a folder
<code>mv old-name new-name</code>	move or rename a file

- If a name contains spaces, put it in quotes: `cd "My Project"`

The current folder is the agent's project boundary

- If you start an agent in `agent-workshop`, it can inspect that project and its instructions.
- If you start it in your home folder, course workspace, or OneDrive root, you may expose unrelated files.

```
Documents/  
├── private-files/           ← not part of this workshop  
├── agent-workshop/         ← start the agent here  
│   ├── AGENTS.md  
│   ├── index.html  
│   ├── styles.css  
│   └── app.js
```

- **Never paste passwords, API keys, private messages, or identifiable data into the agent.**

Create a clean workshop folder

Run each line separately:

```
cd Documents  
mkdir agent-workshop  
cd agent-workshop  
pwd  
ls
```

Your final `pwd` should end in `agent-workshop`.

- If `Documents` is not your preferred location, choose another ordinary folder.
- Do not run the agent from a folder containing unrelated or sensitive files.

Check the shared prerequisite

The npm installation path for both CLI agents requires Node.js and npm. **Try:**

```
node --version  
npm --version
```

If either command is missing:

1. install Node.js from nodejs.org/download
2. close and reopen the terminal
3. repeat above commands

Install and start an agent

Codex CLI

Install once:

```
npm install -g @openai/codex
```

Start it inside `agent-workshop` :

```
codex
```

On first launch, choose **Sign in with ChatGPT** or another available sign-in method.

Copilot CLI

Install once:

```
npm install -g @github/copilot
```

Start it inside `agent-workshop` :

```
copilot
```

Enter `/login` and authenticate with GitHub.

Test your agents

Scope the folder, tools, data, and task before increasing autonomy.

Set your approval level

- **Codex:** inspect or change `/permissions`
- **Copilot CLI:** stay in its default prompt-based mode and approve only specific requests (avoid `/allow-all`)
 - reject unexpected network access, installs, or paths outside the project
- Ask yourself...
 - What will it read, write, install, delete, or send over the network?
 - Is that action necessary for this prototype?
 - Is the target path inside `agent-workshop` ?
 - Can I recover the previous state if the result is wrong?

Set up project boundaries in `AGENTS.md`

- Both Codex and Copilot CLI can use `AGENTS.md`.
- Keep it short, concrete, and versioned with the project.
- Example in GH repo

Making a /plan

- Improved security
 - avoid exposing unwanted files/data
- Potentially more tokens
 - If you make a good plan...
 - Maybe your model can do less later

Prompt examples

- Build a small local website (front end, `html` + `css` + `js`) for one of your agents
 - what should it include?
 - what should it look like?
 - should you mock it up with some data?
- Build a presentation based on your proposed agents from yesterday
 - what format should it use?
 - what's the outline? content?
- Experiment with different prompts and iterations!

Tips for sustainable agent workflows

Before sending another prompt, ask:

- Can I state one concrete change instead of requesting a broad redesign?
- Can the agent inspect a few relevant files instead of the whole drive?
- Can existing tools verify the result without installing a new framework?
- Can I stop once the learning goal works?

Show what you built—and how you governed it

1. project folder and `AGENTS.md`
2. approval you scrutinized or rejected
3. edge case that changed the result
4. thing the prototype deliberately does **not** collect or automate

Common troubleshooting

- Read the error before trying another command.
- Confirm `node --version`, `npm --version`, and your account access.
- Do not grant broad permissions merely to make an error disappear.
- After focused troubleshooting attempt, pair with someone whose agent runs.

Pair roles:

- **Driver:** types prompts and operates the computer.
- **Reviewer:** checks the current folder, approvals, files, and test evidence.
- Swap roles after the first working version.

Official setup references

- [Codex CLI quickstart](#)
- [Codex guidance with AGENTS.md](#)
- [GitHub Copilot CLI quickstart](#)
- [GitHub Copilot CLI tool permissions](#)
- [GitHub Copilot CLI custom instructions](#)
- [Agents in Visual Studio Code](#)
- [Node.js downloads](#)

Setup details checked **21 July 2026**. Product interfaces and installation commands may change; use the linked official documentation if a screen differs.